BLAZE / GAME DESIGN

03 / PLAYABLE SIX-ZONE CAMPAIGN & IMPLEMENTATION

Version 1 player promise

A player can start a new game, meet Blaze and Captain Alden in Forge Gate, survive the Hush invasion, play six sequential zones with six distinct boss encounters, complete the optional Retreat challenge, defeat Blaze’s Shadow, watch the borrowed dawn ending, save their progress, and replay the finished campaign.

Game loop and controls

Primary loop: enter zone → traverse platforms → fight or avoid Mopes → collect sparks → activate beacon checkpoint → reach boss → earn restored color → proceed to next zone.

Input	Action	Game rule
A/D or arrows	Move	Acceleration, deceleration, facing
Space	Jump	Coyote time, jump buffer, variable height
J	Flame Slash	Short-range melee hitbox
K	Crescent Wave	Ranged slash; 3 consecutive waves overheat for 2 seconds
Shift	Ember Dash	Midair/ground burst with cooldown
L	Crimson Cyclone	Full skill meter; clears regular Mopes; hurts bosses
E	Interact	Beacons, dialogue, doors
Esc	Pause	Resume/settings/return

Blaze gameplay identity

- Fast aggressive melee character with a longer combo window (Burning Streak).
- Strength: responsive close combat, mobility and screen clear.
- Weakness: Crescent Wave overheat and vulnerability after missed attacks.

- Growth in gameplay: teach careful timing in the caves and rescue-first choices in Broken River.

Levels and boss acceptance criteria

Zone	Signature mechanic	Boss win condition
Forge Gate prologue	Movement and fight tutorial; evacuation	Alden’s sacrifice cinematic triggered and escape route works
1 · Meadow	Jumping, sparks, splitting enemy groups	Great Mope defeated after split/recombine loop
2 · Hills	Gaps, chase timer, rescue detour	Survive Rolling Gloom to safe exit; not damageable
3 · Woods	Vertical routes and weak points	Destroy corrupted knots to restore Thornmother
4 · Caves	Darkness, visual + audio cues, spikes	Dodge telegraphed Echo Maw attacks and punish openings
5 · River	Rafts, moving platforms, optional side room	Hit Undertow on surfacing; Retreat rescue optional
6 · Summit	Combined mechanics; mirror moves	Defeat Shadow with avoid-and-counter strategy

Difficulty curve

- Prologue: forgiving training, no excessive punishment; establish emotional stakes quickly.
- Meadow: one attack at a time; simple enemy wind-ups.
- Hills: longer jumps and chase with generous initial reaction windows.
- Woods: multiple threats and obvious visual boss weak points.
- Caves: reduced visibility but never hide essential hazards; use accessible visual cues for audio attacks.
- River: moving platforms and controlled pressure; avoid unfair water deaths.
- Summit: all learned mechanics, then final duel with escalating but readable patterns.

Reusable technical modules

Module	Must support
GameShell	React mount/unmount, canvas focus, pause lifecycle
BlazeController	Physics movement, abilities, i-frames, animation states
CombatSystem	Hitboxes, projectiles, enemy reactions, cooldowns
EnemyAI	Mope patrol/chase/attack; boss state machines
LevelLoader	Tilemaps, platform metadata, goal and spawn validation
DialogueDirector	Short checkpoints, portraits, subtitles, skip
ProgressStore	Save version, checkpoints, unlock flags, best scores
BossDirector	Health phases, telegraphs, reset and retry
AudioManager	Music/SFX bus, mute and levels
AssetManifest	Spritesheet frames, animation names, metadata

Checkpoints, saves and scoring

- Activate a beacon to save current zone, spawn point and relevant inventory. Autosave after boss victories.
- Track sparks, deaths, level times, best score, optional secrets, Turning Point success and campaign completion.
- Respawn at checkpoint with clear invulnerability window; do not reset the full campaign after death.
- Store a versioned and validated game save locally for V1; plan backend/cloud sync only later.

Scene and story trigger map

Moment	Trigger	Presentation
Tutorial ends	Complete sparring and interact with Alden	Short scene on the eastern wall
Hush invasion	Approach Gate courtyard	Playable fight → timed Alden sacrifice scene
Waystation lines	Interact with lit beacon	One line memory and warm environmental transition
Boss defeated	Boss health/state completed	Brief scene; environment regains color
The Retreat	Take optional branch in Broken River	Three-child rescue using movement, not combat
Shadow defeated	End of final boss	Dialogue and Emberfang restored flame
Borrowed dawn	Interact with Great Beacon	Reunion, sunset reversal, next-hero promise

Accessibility and QA

- Offer remappable controls where possible, gamepad support, subtitle legibility, scalable UI, color plus shape indicators and disable-shake option.
- Test all required jumps, boss reset behavior, fall deaths, reloading checkpoints, pause focus, and every save migration.
- A campaign cannot be called complete until all boss endings, exit gates, save/continue and credits actually work.

Milestones

- M1: Phaser 4 mounted into React; movement, attacks, damage and basic HUD.
- M2: Forge Gate + Meadow + Great Mope polished and tested.
- M3: Hills and Woods complete; chase, rescue, knot-based boss.
- M4: Caves and River complete; Echo Maw, Undertow, optional Turning Point.
- M5: Summit, Shadow, temporary dawn ending, save/resume and QA.